# Island Express

**YOU CAN NOW REACH Lakshadweep by sea from the mainland in just seven hours! A new high-speed ferry service named 'Parali' was launched in May to connect mainland India to the island, significantly reducing travel time from the customary 13 hours. This modern vessel promises a smoother journey compared to the older, modified cargo ferries in use. The Lakshadweep Islands Tourism Development Authority is also enhancing services and facilities at Kadmat, the primary port for travellers arriving from the mainland, to ensure a more comfortable travel experience. The new service plies between Mangaluru and Lakshadweep, with tickets priced at around Rs 5,000 per person. This initiative is expected to boost tourism to Lakshadweep, an archipelago of 36 islands famed for its pristine beaches, coral reefs, and peaceful environment.** ■

*Satarupa Paul*

SHUTTERSTOCK

# Golden Milestone

## Bhutan celebrates 50 years of tourism with a range of special events



Since Bhutan's tourism journey began in 1974, the scenic Himalayan kingdom has presented strong examples of keeping overtourism at bay. Its policy of 'high value, low volume' established the foundation of mindful tourism, much before it became a buzzword. Bhutan is the world's only country to implement a $100 Sustainable Development Fee (SDF) per adult, per night, for all its visitors. For Indians, it's Rs 1,200. These funds are utilised for the upkeep of cultural heritage and for providing free healthcare and education to the Bhutanese.

The idea has always been to generate revenue through tourism by showcasing Bhutan's strengths, without causing harm to the environment. This year marks five decades of that commitment. Bhutan's Department of Tourism launched a campaign on June 2, to celebrate this landmark occasion. The festivities will extend until December 17, Bhutan's National Day.

In August, the country will host its first tourism awards to recognise excellence and innovation. Besides, there will be TedX talks by public figures from Bhutan, who will discuss pertinent tourism-related subjects. A jewellery showcase and fashion show to highlight the craftsmanship are also on the cards. There will also be events at Bhutanese embassies worldwide, besides industry initiatives, including the launch of new itineraries, introduction of a loyalty programme, etc. ■

*Geetika Sachdev*